manufacturing about five lakh kits per week starting April 2020.[5] The Indian mission in South Korea played an important role in ensuring that the company's unit in Manesar got all the necessary clearances required in South Korea and India. The licences were facilitated without delay by the ICMR and the Drugs Controller General of India (DCGI) in a matter of days. However, the episode of receiving faulty medical equipment from China ended up leaving a rather sour taste in the mouths of countries which were grappling with the virus, and banking on aggressive testing and treating to 'flatten the curve'.



A strong supply chain for essential products had to be established, especially for the equipment which we had scarce stockpiles of and didn't manufacture domestically in large quantities. When the review meeting to forecast the requirement for essentials took place with PMO officials in March, the direction to the empowered groups was clear: become self-sufficient in the production of essentials as soon as possible. The Ministry of External Affairs was instructed to maintain cordial bilateral relations with the countries from whom we would be sourcing essentials in the weeks or months to come, till we became fully self-reliant. This was to be done through the respective Indian missions in these countries. During a meeting in the last days of January 2020, it had become clear that we didn't manufacture a single PPE kit; in fact, we didn't even have SOPs in place to manufacture PPE kits. We only had about 2.75 lakh imported kits stockpiled with us. In the meeting at the PMO in early March, NITI Aayog officials, led by Dr Paul and Amitabh Kant, forecasted that India would need about 20 million of them by July 2020. This meant that India would need to make 20,000 PPE kits with a classification of Class-3 protection level under ISO 16603 standards per day to meet this upcoming target. Even before the meeting in March, looking at the abysmal numbers stockpiled with us, the MoHFW and the Ministry of Textiles had deployed teams to understand the gaps in the existing infrastructure and resources and in the overall end-to-end production, testing and packaging of the kits as per WHO-approved quality standards. On 18 March, the Ministry of Textiles decided to prohibit the export of domestically manufactured PPEs and raw materials for the same, the notification for which was issued the next day. The team, led by